

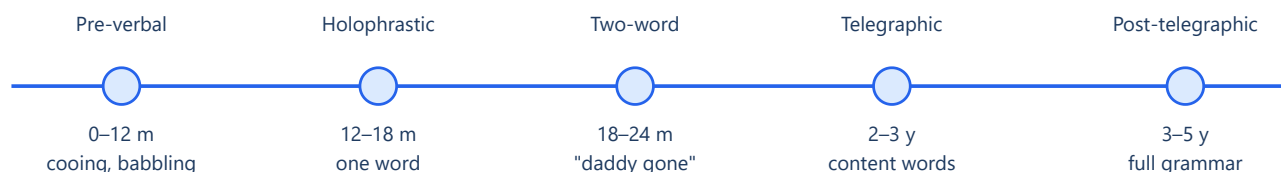
● RAG Learning

2.1 Children's Spoken Language Development

Edexcel A-Level English Language (9EN0) — Paper 2 Child Language

Paper 2 assesses your ability to analyse how children acquire their first language between birth and around age 8. You need to know the **stages** of phonological, lexical, grammatical and pragmatic development, the major **theorists** (Skinner, Chomsky, Piaget, Vygotsky, Bruner, Halliday, Tomasello), and how to apply all of this to an unseen transcript. The paper is 1 hour 15 minutes and worth 20% of the A-level.

Stages of Spoken Language Development (approximate ages)



2.1.1 Stages of Development

Pre-verbal (0–12 months)

- Crying / reflexive vocalisation (0–2 months).
- Cooing (2–5 months) — vowel-like sounds.
- Babbling (6–12 months) — reduplicated syllables ("bababa"), then variegated.
- By 12 months, babbling narrows to phonemes of the ambient language.

Holophrastic / one-word (12–18 months)

Single words function as whole utterances. "Milk" might mean "I want milk", "that is milk", "where is the milk". Context disambiguates. Katherine Nelson (1973), tracking 18 children, sorted the first 50 words into six categories and found the vocabulary dominated by **general nominals** — everyday class nouns such as *ball, dog, car* — at about 51%. **Specific nominals** (names for one particular thing: *Mummy*, a pet's name) made up only about 14%, with **action words** ~13%, **modifiers** ~9%, **personal-social** words ~8% and grammatical **function words** ~4%.

Two-word stage (18–24 months)

Two content words in consistent semantic relations: *daddy gone, more juice, no bed*. Word order is typically target-like.

Telegraphic stage (2–3 years)

Three+ content words, function words (articles, auxiliaries, inflections) often omitted: *daddy gone shop, me want biscuit*.

Post-telegraphic (3–5 years)

Function words appear; tense, aspect and agreement become regular; embedded clauses emerge; questions with subject–auxiliary inversion develop. By school age most core grammar is acquired.

2.1.2 Phonological Development

- **Cluster reduction** — "poon" for "spoon".
- **Substitution** — /w/ for /r/, /d/ for /ð/.
- **Deletion** of unstressed syllables — "nana" for "banana".
- **Assimilation** — "doggy" → "goggy".
- **Fis phenomenon** — child says "fis" for "fish" but rejects an adult saying "fis" — perception leads production.

2.1.3 Lexical and Semantic Development

- **Overextension** — a word used too broadly: "dog" for all four-legged animals.

- **Underextension** — a word used too narrowly: "dog" only for the family pet.
- **Mismatch errors** — unrelated reference.
- **Vocabulary spurt** — around 18 months.

2.1.4 Grammatical Development & Virtuous Errors

A **virtuous error** is an overgeneralisation of a rule: "goed", "mouses". The child has never heard these forms; they are produced by applying a rule. Decisive evidence against pure imitation.

The **Berko wug test** (1958) showed children reliably plural a novel "wug" as "wugs" — productive knowledge of the plural morpheme.

2.1.5 Pragmatic Development & Halliday's Functions

Function	Purpose	Example
Instrumental	Getting needs met	"want juice"
Regulatory	Controlling others' behaviour	"no bed"
Interactional	Maintaining social bonds	"hi mummy"
Personal	Expressing feelings / identity	"me happy"
Heuristic	Exploring / learning	"what's that?"
Imaginative	Play / fantasy	"I'm a dragon"
Representational	Conveying information	"doggy barking"

2.1.6 Theories of Acquisition

Behaviourism — Skinner

Children learn through imitation, operant conditioning, and positive reinforcement. **Evaluation:** cannot explain virtuous errors or novel utterances; rarely receive explicit correction yet still converge on adult grammar.

Nativism — Chomsky

Innate **Language Acquisition Device (LAD)** and **Universal Grammar**. Evidence: poverty of the stimulus, virtuous errors, critical period (Lenneberg), universals across languages.

Cognitive — Piaget

Language depends on underlying cognitive development. Children cannot use a concept linguistically before they have grasped it cognitively. Limitation: Vygotsky shows language can drive cognition too.

Social interactionism — Bruner, Vygotsky

- **Bruner (LASS)** — Language Acquisition Support System: joint attention, recasting, expansion, routines.
- **Vygotsky (ZPD)** — the gap between what a learner can do alone and with guidance.
- **Trevarthen** — proto-conversations: pre-verbal turn-taking with gaze and vocalisation.
- **Tomasello** — usage-based theory: grammar learned from patterns; shared intentionality is central.

2.1.7 Child-Directed Speech (CDS)

Caregivers' register with infants:

- Higher pitch, exaggerated intonation.
- Slower tempo, clearer articulation.
- Simplified, concrete vocabulary.
- Repetition and routines.
- Recasting — repeating the child's utterance in full form.
- Expansion — adding information to what the child said.

- Reference to the here-and-now supporting joint attention.

Applied Example: A picture-book routine at 18 months exemplifies multiple theories at once: joint attention (Bruner), exaggerated prosody (CDS), labelling supporting Halliday's heuristic function, scaffolding within the ZPD (Vygotsky), and input that activates innate capacity (Chomsky). Top-band exam answers weave several theorists together.

2.1.8 Key Evidence

Genie (Curtiss, 1977)

Girl isolated from language until age 13. After rescue she acquired lexis but not complex grammar — cited as evidence for the critical period. Caveats: single case, trauma as confound.

Jim (hearing child of deaf parents)

Exposed to language mainly through TV, failed to acquire full grammar. Shows input alone is not enough; *interactional* input is essential.

Tomasello's studies

Infants track speaker intention from around 12–14 months; shared intentionality is central to word learning.

2.1.9 Analysing a Transcript

1. Estimate the **stage** from utterance length, grammar, lexis.
2. Note **phonological** features.
3. Analyse **lexis / semantics** (over/underextensions, vocabulary choice).
4. Analyse **grammar / morphology** (word order, inflections, virtuous errors, subordination).
5. Apply **Halliday's functions**.
6. Consider **caregiver scaffolding** (recasting, expansion, questioning).

7. Apply **two theorists** explicitly, anchoring each claim in the transcript.

Exam Tip: Don't just name-drop theorists. Anchor each theoretical claim in specific features of the transcript. "The child says 'I goed' — a virtuous error showing rule over-generalisation. This supports Chomsky's nativist account: the child cannot have imitated a form they have never heard."

Key Terms Checklist

Make sure you can define: **pre-verbal / holophrastic / two-word / telegraphic / post-telegraphic stages, babbling, cooing, overextension, underextension, virtuous error, wug test, CDS (motherese), recasting, expansion, LAD, LASS, ZPD, joint attention, critical period, Halliday's seven functions, fis phenomenon, Genie, Tomasello, proto-conversation.**